

Zero Sum RPG Scenario: 001 - The Lithium Bleed



Real-World Inspiration

Based on the massive supply-chain bottlenecks and geopolitical corporate sabotage seen in the 2026 EV battery sector.

Background

A remote, highly automated lithium refinement plant in the Nevada desert has been quietly acquired by a shell company working for the Sovereign Wealth Syndicate. They are deliberately adulterating the lithium output with microscopic corrosive agents to cause millions of Western electric vehicles to catch fire within the next 18 months, effectively crashing the global stock market.

The Zero Sum Twist

The facility is fully automated. There are no human guards on the perimeter—only AI-driven lethal drones and automated turrets. However, the plant's core reactor requires constant chemical balancing. If the players trigger an alarm, the system locks down and initiates a chemical purge, flooding the facility with highly toxic hydrofluoric acid gas.

Zero Sum Consistency Matrix (ZSCM)

- **E (Lethality Expectation) = 5:** Combat is against machines, meaning lethal force is authorized, but the machines are heavily armored.
- **R (Resource Scarcity) = 6:** EMPs and armor-piercing rounds are necessary but extremely rare.
- **I (Intel Asymmetry) = 7:** The drone patrol routes are controlled by a predictive AI that learns from the players' movements.
- **D (Collateral Damage Risk) = 8:** A stray bullet hitting a chemical vat triggers the "Environmental Load" rule (toxic fumes).

Total ZSCM Score = 26/30 (Hardcore Tactical).

Key NPCs & Obstacles

- **The Overseer AI:** The plant's central intelligence. It doesn't negotiate, it only calculates kill probabilities.
- **The "Cleaners" (PMC):** A rapid-response team stationed 10 minutes away by helicopter. They only arrive if the AI calls them.

Objective

1. Bypass the drone perimeter.
2. Hack the main terminal to stop the adulteration process.
3. Exfiltrate before the chemical purge is triggered.